Niki & Juan,

Thank you for completing the couples therapy assessment. The assessments were crucial in helping me effectively evaluate and understand your current relationship. The Gottman Method is a couples therapy approach based on 40 years of research at the Gottman Institute. This research has identified particular behaviors that help couples stay together, emphasizing the importance of friendship, conflict management, and building meaning. Relationships that thrive have seven layers that build upon each other.

Relationships that thrive have 7 layers and they each build upon each other.

Love Maps

The first three levels of the Sound Relationship House (SRH) constitute friendship, which is the foundation of a strong relationship. The first level is Love Maps, which entails how well you know one another—specifically, your partner's inner psychological world, including their worries, stresses, joys, and dreams. It involves asking open-ended questions and maintaining awareness of your partner's world. A positive aspect of your relationship is that both of you feel known by one another and are satisfied with your Love Maps.

I want to reflect that you have built a friendship in which each of you feels genuinely known by the other, with a clear awareness of each other's hopes and aspirations, and that this is a real strength in your relationship. A strong friendship is not just meaningful, it is closely linked to long-lasting relationships as well as sustained passion and romance over time. I encourage you to continue nurturing this by building your Love Maps and staying curious about one another, continually learning more about each other's inner worlds so that your friendship, and in turn your relationship, can remain deep, resilient, and alive.

Fondness and Admiration

The second level is Fondness and Admiration, which serves as the antidote for contempt. This level involves shifting your mindset from scanning for your partner's mistakes to recognizing what they are doing right and fostering a culture of appreciation, fondness, affection, and respect.

While the online scores were high, your interview assessments revealed that you could both work on cultivating a culture of appreciation. When fondness and admiration begin to fade in a relationship, it is often linked to periods of poor conflict management, unresolved emotional injuries or betrayals, turning away from each other's attempts to connect, or holding back from expressing your own needs. I encourage you to reflect on how these circumstances resonate with your experience together.

Begin asking- "How can I help my partner feel loved, desired, and appreciated?" . Beyond appreciating what your partner does, you can go deeper by naming things you appreciate about your partner's personality and who they are.

Turning Towards:

The third level is Turn Towards vs. Turning away in everyday moments. The small moments of everyday life are actually the building blocks of a relationship. A partner has the opportunity to either turn towards, turn away, or turn against a bid from his or her partner. A bid is a gesture—verbal or nonverbal—for some sort of positive connection: conversation, humor, affection, or support. The very small everyday moments in a relationship are opportunities—opportunities for Turning Towards one another. Accept bids for emotional connection and make deposits into the Emotional Bank Account.

Both scores and the interviews reveal that on a deeper level, there are emotional needs and vulnerabilities that need to receive attention and care from both partners.

This is the level that builds trust. *The research defines trust in a committed relationship as: The state that occurs when you believe your partner has your best interest in mind and acts in ways that benefit you. It's knowing your partner values your interests and needs as much as their own. In other words, this means, "my partner has my back and is there for me." The highest bids for attention are the ones that come from a long standing childhood place and they are pieces of attention you would like to receive from your partner. These are the sort of bids that invite huge opportunities to build trust.*

Trust is low.

The recent experience of turning away/against have made the issue of trust a point of deep challenge. In addition there is accumulated 'turning aways' during times where you both needed each other to be present emotionally.

I recommend taking the time each day to scan for opportunities to turn towards your partner, no matter how small.

We may need to consider how the culture of 'turning towards' in your families of origin differ and how to develop a relationship culture where both styles of turning towards are understood while accommodating for each other's emotional needs better.

The Positive Perspective:

The first three levels determine whether this level is positive or negative. A positive perspective occurs when friendship is strong. This level represents what it feels like in the relationship. Whether this level is positive or negative determines a lot of things, including the presence of positive affect in problem-solving discussions and the success of repair attempts during conflict resolution. If the first three levels of the Sound Relationship House are not working, then couples tend to be in a negative perspective and are hyper-vigilant for negativity.

People are in negative perspective for a good reason: they see their partner as an adversary, not a friend. To change that state, you need to build the friendship in your relationship, using the first three levels of the Sound Relationship House.

This level of the house would appear to be in a negative sentiment override, because of missing each other in the 'turning towards' level above. The more level 3 is managed, the better level 4 will be. Take the time to consider this negative perspective that may be over-riding or tainting the way you may be perceiving your partner's intention.

CONFLICT MANAGEMENT:
We use the term **"managing" conflict rather than "resolving"** conflict because relationship conflict is natural and it has functional, positive aspects.

A. Manage Conflict: Perpetual Problems

Relationships work to the extent you and your partner can learn to live with your perpetual problems. When a problem is a perpetual problem, as the majority of couples' problems are, instead of solving it, learn how to dialogue about your different subjective realities. The masters of relationships seem to be able to come to some acceptance of their problems. They are able to simultaneously communicate acceptance of their partner and the desire to improve the problem, often with amusement, respect, and affection. However, if they cannot establish such a dialogue, their conflict may become gridlocked which eventually leads to emotional disengagement.

Your emotion philosophies are different and that has been the deeper source of conflict. The big task here is to develop a safe way to have dialogue or to be with conflict in ways that feel tolerable. Self regulation and awareness of the other are both equally important.

B. Manage Conflict: Solvable Problems

Use these six skills to help manage conflict: **practice self-soothing, use softened startups, make repairs and de-escalate, listen to your partner's underlying feelings and dreams, accept influence, and compromise.**

*The assessment revealed that **harsh start ups** are an issue and so learning to soften when beginning a dialogue that is difficult or sharing upset with your partner needs to be worked on.*

*In addition **flooding** could be worked on. This is a physiological phenomenon that happens for some during a conflict. Flooding happens when your central nervous*

system gets overwhelmed and you are propelled to "flight", "fight" or "freeze". You are likely no longer in your usual state of mind. When flooded, you will need to learn self soothing, or co-regulate and to give each other space/connection or time to return to equilibrium. The brain takes about 30 minutes to return to equilibrium. This can take the form of shutting down or emotional dissociation, a sense of wanting to leave or escape the tension or situational violence. This is learned behavior just as much as it is an evolutionary-biological process.

Repair Attempts

You could work on making successful repair attempts and allowing the other to be successful as well. There is currently a negative cycle present where repair attempts are rejected and things spiral. In addition, many times, there are no repair attempts and tension persists without the care that it needs.

Being open to your partner's attempts to repair is a shift in mindset and can happen when emotions are more regulated.

Influence

Part of having a successful partnership is feeling a sense of co-influence. Allowing your partner to influence you and feeling you influence your partner keeps the connection alive. A metaphor I like using is that you are co-staring in a movie of your love life together. A "yes-and" attitude rather than a "my way or the high way" attitude is recommended.

We could work on this more. Learning to use compromise skills can help with this.

THE 4 HORSEMEN ARE PRESENT…

Criticism

Criticism is blaming a relationship problem on personality flaws in your partner;

The antidote to criticism is using soft rather than harsh start ups and describing what you want rather that what you dislike.

Defensiveness

Defensiveness is defending against your partner's criticism or contempt by either denying any responsibility for the problem, acting like an innocent victim, or counter-attacking your partner by criticizing him or her while ignoring his or her complaints

The antidote to defensiveness is just acknowledging your partner's reality. Take responsibility and validate your partner's perspective. Validation does not mean agreement. It just means, you respect your partner's experience.

Contempt

Contempt means combining criticism of your partner with descriptions of your own superiority and disgust with your partner

This really needs to be avoided completely and the main antidote is returning to just describing what you want and expressing love towards your partner.

Stonewalling

Stonewalling involves shutting down completely and refusing to offer any verbal or non-verbal responses to your partner's statements. Stonewalling may be accompanied by flooding

Antidote to this is recognizing when a disagreement gets overwhelming and figuring out what to do.

Harsh Start-Ups

The Gottmans can predict how well an argument will go within the first couple of seconds of a conflict.

The assessment revealed the use of harsh start ups. We will look at how both of you can change they way you bring up complaints or disagreements. Starting soft often predicts a positive outcome for conflict. Let's learn how to do this.

Compromise

We need to learn the fundamentals of compromise and practice this in session

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Meta-Emotions/Conflict Styles

Each individual has a unique philosophy one emotion management that stem from childhood. there is a way in which partners expect the other to manage each emotions like happiness, sadness, anger etc.

There is a difference in the ways both of you expect negative emotions to be expressed and managed in the relationship. This difference in expectations have affected conflict management and so taking the time to work these out are important. We will spend a lot of time on this.

Meta-emotions drive the way we think of conflict management. You have different conflict styles. Niki has a volitile-validating conflict style while Juan has an avoidant style. The volitile-validating and avoidant conflict styles differ significantly in how partners handle disagreements. People with a volitile-validating style prefer to address issues directly, engaging in emotionally expressive discussions with the intention to not only express their needs but also to understand each other's perspectives and achieve more intimacy. They believe that open communication strengthens the relationship and value emotional expression as a way to resolve problems. In contrast, those with an avoidant style tend to minimize or sidestep conflict altogether, believing that confrontation is

destabilizing. They prefer to let issues fade on their own, often suppressing their emotions to maintain harmony and avoid uncomfortable conversations.

When these two styles are mismatched in a relationship, it can create a frustrating dynamic. The volitile-validating partner may feel ignored or dismissed when their efforts to talk things through are met with withdrawal or silence, while the avoidant partner can feel overwhelmed by the push for discussion or emotionally intense contact. This can lead to unresolved issues piling up, misunderstandings, and a sense of emotional distance. Despite these challenges, this pairing can work if both partners make an effort to understand and respect each other's needs- volitile-validators can give avoidants space, and avoidants can commit to addressing issues in small, manageable ways. With mutual empathy and communication, the differences can be bridged.

Making Life Dreams Come True

Find ways to support each other's life goals and dreams. A crucial aspect of any relationship is creating an atmosphere that encourages each person to talk honestly about his or her dreams, values, convictions, and aspirations.

Right now you are unaware of your partner's deeper dreams and the conflict and gridlock feels as if dreams are being stepped on. Discovering the deeper dreams within the conflicts may help bridge understanding and connection.

SHARED MEANING

Shared Meaning is comprised of your Rituals, Roles, Goals, Values, and Symbols of your relationship.

Here, we come to the attic of the Sound Relationship House. This is what you tell yourself about your relationship, your internal thoughts, metaphors, myths, and stories. Everyone is a philosopher trying to make some sense out of this brief journey through life. This level of the Sound Relationship House is about creating shared meaning in the relationship. People create shared meaning intentionally by talking about:

• Rituals of Connection (formal and informal)

- Shared goals.
- Supporting each other's life roles
- Agreeing about basic symbols such as what a home means

Conflict, emotional pain has made all of this very difficult, However with new skills and a renewed understanding of each other, you could be building shared meaning around your parenting and family life.